



IAN WILLMS FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Pope Francis at Lac Ste. Anne in Alberta this week. Regarding his use of a wheelchair, he said recently, “That’s how it is, that’s life.”

**Tough Choices
In a U.S. Deal
To Free Griner**

By PETER BAKER

WASHINGTON — One is perhaps the world’s most notorious arms dealer, a man known as the “Merchant of Death” who sold weapons to terrorists, rebels and militants around the world before finally being hunted down and locked up for conspiring to kill Americans.

The other is a basketball player who got caught with a little hashish oil.

By no measure are they comparable, yet the Biden administration has proposed trading the merchant of death for the imprisoned basketball player as well as a former marine held in Russia on what are considered trumped-up espionage charges. In the harsh and cynical world of international diplomacy, prisoner exchanges are rarely pretty, but unpalatable choices are often the only choices on the table.

Whether the swap would go through remained unclear. Secretary of State Antony J. Blinken made the offer public in part to reassure the families of Brittney Griner, the basketball player, and Paul N. Whelan, the former marine, that the administration is doing all it can to free them.

Russian officials, who have long sought the release of the arms trafficker Viktor Bout, confirmed the discussion on Thursday but said Foreign Minister Sergey V. Lavrov was too busy to talk with Mr. Blinken now.

The disclosure of the negotiations raised obvious questions about what, if any, standards should apply when the United States agrees to trade prisoners, a conundrum that has challenged the nation’s leaders since its

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Pope Makes His Frailty a Lesson in Compassion

By JASON HOROWITZ

LAC STE. ANNE, Alberta — When Pope Francis landed in Canada this week, he lumbered out of a car on the tarmac, hobbled with difficulty to an awaiting wheelchair and froze in place as cameras shot at close range the spectacle of an aide adjusting the pontiff’s footrests.

On a makeshift stage outside an Indigenous cemetery in Alberta, the world watched as he gathered his strength and grasped the arms of the aide, who lifted him out of his wheelchair.

In Lac Ste. Anne, a remote lake renowned for its miraculous healing powers, hundreds of wor-

**Now 85, He Preaches
Care and Dignity for
Aging Population**

shippers waiting for Francis in a shrine adorned with the crutches and canes of the cured gasped in unison as the pope’s wheelchair hit a snag and he lurched dangerously forward.

A Vatican video feed quickly cut away. But seeing Francis in his increasing frailty and advancing old age was very much a point of his visit.

While the pontiff’s main mis-

sion in Canada was what he called a “pilgrimage of penance” to apologize to Indigenous people for the horrific abuses they endured in church-run residential schools, it was also a pilgrimage of senescence in which the pontiff, 85, used his own vulnerability to demand dignity for the aged in a world increasingly populated by them.

There needed to be built “a future in which the elderly are not cast aside because, from a ‘practical’ standpoint, they are no longer useful,” Francis said at a Mass at Commonwealth Stadium in Edmonton, Alberta, one of the few events in a papal travel schedule

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HOMEWARD TRAILS ANIMAL RESCUE

Bound for Belly Rubs and Grassy Yards

Some 4,000 beagles that were headed for testing labs didn’t have names or know how to play. Volunteers are now preparing them for lives with foster owners and adoptive families. Page A9.

Justice Dept., Wary of Backlash, Treads Lightly in Jan. 6 Inquiry

This article is by Glenn Thrush, Adam Goldman and Katie Benner.

As the Justice Department investigation into the attack on the Capitol grinds ever closer to former President Donald J. Trump, it has prompted persistent — and cautionary — reminders of the backlash caused by inquiries into Mr. Trump and Hillary Clinton

during the 2016 presidential campaign.

Attorney General Merrick B. Garland is intent on avoiding even the slightest errors, which could taint the current investigation, provide Mr. Trump’s defenders with reasons to claim the inquiry was driven by animus, or undo his effort to rehabilitate the department’s reputation after the political warfare of the Trump years.

**Seeking to Avoid Errors
of 2016 Investigations**

Mr. Garland never seriously considered focusing on Mr. Trump from the outset, as investigators had done earlier with Mr. Trump and with Mrs. Clinton during her email investigation, people close

to him say. As a result, his investigators have taken a more methodical approach, carefully climbing up the chain of personnel behind the 2020 plan to name fake slates of Trump electors in battleground states that had been won by Joseph R. Biden Jr.

That has now led them to Mr. Trump and his innermost circle: Justice Department lawyers are

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**ECONOMY SHRINKS
AGAIN, AMPLIFYING
FEAR OF RECESSION**

**G.D.P. Falls for Second Straight Quarter
as the Fed Tries to Tame Inflation**

By BEN CASSELMAN

A key measure of economic output fell for the second straight quarter, raising fears that the United States could be entering a recession — or perhaps that one had already begun.

Gross domestic product, adjusted for inflation, fell 0.2 percent in the second quarter, the Commerce Department said Thursday. That drop followed a decline of 0.4 percent in the first quarter. The estimates for both periods will be revised in coming months as government statisticians get more complete data.

News of the back-to-back contractions heightened a debate in Washington over whether a recession had begun and, if so, whether President Biden was to blame. Economists largely say that conditions do not meet the formal definition of a recession but that the risks of one are rising.

For most people, though, a “recession” label matters less than the economic reality: Growth is slowing, businesses are pulling back and families are having a harder time keeping up with rapidly rising prices.

“We’re absolutely losing momentum,” said Tim Quinlan, a senior economist for Wells Fargo. “Income gains at minimum have struggled to keep pace with inflation, and that’s what is chipping away at people’s ability to spend.”

A deceleration, on its own, isn’t necessarily bad news. The Federal Reserve has been trying to cool the economy in a bid to tame inflation, and the White House has argued that the slowdown is part of an inevitable and necessary transition to sustainable growth after last year’s rapid recovery.

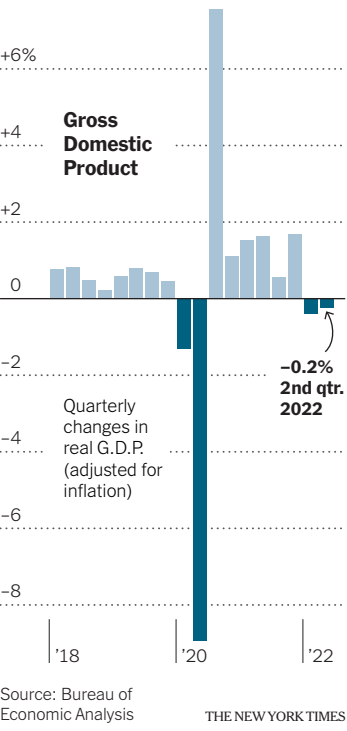
“Coming off of last year’s historic economic growth — and regaining all the private-sector jobs

lost during the pandemic crisis — it’s no surprise that the economy is slowing down as the Federal Reserve acts to bring down inflation,” Mr. Biden said in a statement issued after the release of the G.D.P. report. “But even as we face historic global challenges, we are on the right path, and we will come through this transition stronger and more secure.”

Still, forecasters in recent weeks have become increasingly concerned that the Fed’s aggressive moves — including raising interest rates three-quarters of a percentage point on Wednesday for the second month in a row — will result in a recession.

Jerome H. Powell, the Fed

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**Two Democrats
Buried Grudges
To Salvage Deal**

By EMILY COCHRANE and ANNIE KARNI

WASHINGTON — Senator Chuck Schumer, the majority leader, and Senator Joe Manchin III, Democrat of West Virginia, were both nursing resentments when they met secretly in a windowless room in the basement of the Capitol last Monday to try to salvage a climate package that was a key piece of their party’s agenda.

Mr. Schumer was discouraged that Mr. Manchin had said he wasn’t ready to do the deal this summer, and might never be. Mr. Manchin was frustrated that Democrats had spent days publicly vilifying him for single-handedly torpedoing their agenda.

“You still upset?” Mr. Manchin asked Mr. Schumer as their aides scoured the hallways outside to ensure the attempt at a truce would not be detected by other senators or reporters.

It was the start of a frenzied and improbable effort by a tiny group of Democrats, carried out over 10 days and entirely in secret, that succeeded this week in reviving the centerpiece of President Biden’s domestic policy plan — and held out the prospect of a major victory for his party months before the midterm congressional elections.

The talks were driven by major concessions made to Mr. Manchin — who demanded fewer tax in-

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**In Climate Bill,
U.S. Gets Reset
On World Stage**

By LISA FRIEDMAN and BRAD PLUMER

WASHINGTON — The \$369 billion climate and tax package forged in a surprise deal by Senate Democrats would be the most ambitious action ever taken by the United States to try to stop the planet from catastrophically overheating.

The agreement, which Senate Democrats announced late Wednesday and hope to pass as early as next week, shocked even some who had been involved in the sputtering negotiations over climate legislation during the past year. The announcement of a deal, after many activists had given up hope, almost instantly reset the role of the United States in the global effort to fight climate change.

And it was delivered by Senator Joe Manchin III of West Virginia, the holdout Democrat who had been reviled by environmentalists and some of his own colleagues after he said this month that he could not support a climate bill because of inflation concerns.

“By a wide margin, this legislation will be the greatest pro-climate legislation that has ever been passed by Congress,” Senator Chuck Schumer, the Democratic majority leader, said in announcing the deal with Mr. Manchin.

The bill aims to tackle global warming by using billions of dol-

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An Overly Loved New Bridge
The long-awaited Sixth Street Viaduct in Los Angeles has become an instant icon, and a headache. PAGE A10

U.S. Investigates N.Y.P.D.
Rape survivors’ letters drew a federal inquiry after local officials failed to act on their complaints. PAGE A14

INTERNATIONAL A4-8

Iran’s Drone Export Ambitions
Tehran has quietly ramped up the sale of drone technology to countries outside the Mideast to help carve out its status as a global market player. Now, Russia may be a potential client. PAGE A4

Pushing Up the Heat in Britain
Human-caused climate change worsened last week’s record-shattering heat wave, scientists found. And while such temperature spikes are still rare, they are now more likely. PAGE A5

David Brooks PAGE A23



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Mets Flex, Yankees Reflect
Even after being swept, the Yankees still had the most wins in baseball and a new All-Star in Andrew Benintendi. PAGE B8

A Washington Scandal
Despite evidence of misconduct, Daniel Snyder will keep the city’s N.F.L. team, Kurt Streeter writes. PAGE B9

BUSINESS B1-6

JetBlue to Buy Spirit Airlines
The deal was announced a day after Frontier’s bid for Spirit fell apart, but it is likely to face intense scrutiny on antitrust grounds. PAGE B1

F.T.C. Changes the Game
The Federal Trade Commission has shifted how competition is regulated with a lawsuit against Meta that challenges a nascent tech area. PAGE B1

A Union First for Trader Joe’s
A store in Hadley, Mass., is becoming the only one of the company’s more than 500 locations to unionize, after a 45-to-31 vote by employees. PAGE B6



WEEKEND ARTS C1-12

They Saw Glory in the Grid
The Met surveys the photographers Bernd and Hilla Becher, who turned monuments like cooling towers and blast furnaces into curios. PAGE C1

